

Word family: **bitter** / bitterer / bitterest / bitterly / bitterness

Base word: bitter

Comparative: bitterer / more bitter

Superlative: bitterest / most bitter

Adverb: bitterly

Noun: bitterness

Useful constructions/extensions: bitter taste, bitter coffee, become bitter, bitter about something, bitter experience, bitter disappointment, bitter argument, bitter rivals, bitter enemy, bitter cold, bitterly disappointed, complain bitterly, bitterness

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related adverb and noun forms (相關副詞及名詞)

Your passage contains:

> “I also admire the way she has handled hardship in life without becoming **bitter**.”

Here, **bitter** means:

resentful, angry, or emotionally hardened because of painful or unfair experiences.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **without becoming bitter**

your grandmother has experienced:

> hardship

but those difficult experiences have **not** caused her to become:

- * resentful;
- * angry at life;
- * hostile toward other people;
- * emotionally hardened;
- * constantly focused on past unfairness.

Instead, she remains:

- * kind;
- * patient;
- * thoughtful;
- * warm.

****Meaning:**** Feeling lasting resentment, anger, or unhappiness because you believe you have been treated unfairly or have suffered greatly.

****繁體中文：****因受苦、受委屈或遭遇不公平而變得怨恨、憤憤不平或心懷不滿

****中文翻譯：****

> “She has handled hardship in life without becoming bitter.”

「她經歷人生中的困境，卻沒有因此變得怨恨、憤世嫉俗或心懷不滿。」

So:

****become bitter = 因不好的經歷而逐漸變得怨恨 / 憤憤不平****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****bitter = having a sharp unpleasant taste (苦的) — 苦的；帶苦味的****

This is the basic literal meaning.

****Meaning:**** Having a strong, sharp taste that is not sweet and is often unpleasant.

Practice 1

> “The medicine tastes ****bitter****.”

「這種藥味道很苦。」

Practice 2

> “The coffee was too ****bitter**** for me.”

「這杯咖啡對我來說太苦了。」

****bitter = 味道強烈而帶苦味，與 sweet 等味覺形成對比****

2. ****bitter taste/flavour (苦味) — 苦澀的味道****

Practice 3

> “The vegetables have a slightly ****bitter taste****.”

「這些蔬菜帶一點****苦味****。」

Practice 4

> “Dark chocolate can have a bitter flavour.”

「黑朱古力可以帶有****苦澀味****。」

****bitter taste = 食物 / 飲品帶有明顯的苦味****

This is still the literal taste sense.

3. ****bitter = resentful because of bad experiences (怨恨的) — 憤憤不平 ; 心懷怨恨****

This is the exact figurative meaning used in your passage.

Practice 5 — Original

> “She has handled hardship in life without becoming ****bitter****.”

「她經歷人生困境，卻沒有因此變得****心懷怨恨****。」

Practice 6

> “He became ****bitter**** after years of disappointment.”

「多年的失望令他變得****憤憤不平 / 怨恨****。」

Practice 7

> “She refused to become bitter about what had happened.”

「她不願因發生過的事而變得****怨恨****。」

****bitter = 因痛苦、不公平或失望而長期帶著憤怒和怨氣****

4. ****bitter about something (因某事耿耿於懷) — 怨恨 ; 憤憤不平****

A major construction.

Practice 8

> “He is still ****bitter about**** losing his job.”

「他對失去工作一事仍然****耿耿於懷 / 憤憤不平****。」

Practice 9

> “She was bitter about the way she had been treated.”

「她對自己受到的待遇感到非常****不滿和怨恨****。」

****be bitter about X = 因某件不愉快 / 不公平的事情而長時間心懷不滿****

5. ****bitter toward someone (對某人懷恨) — 怨恨某人****

Practice 10

> “He became ****bitter toward**** his former colleague.”

「他開始對以前的同事****心懷怨恨****。」

Practice 11

> “She had every reason to be angry, but she was not bitter toward anyone.”

「她完全有理由生氣，但她沒有對任何人****懷恨在心****。」

****bitter toward someone = 因過去傷害 / 不公平待遇而對某人持續有怨恨****

6. ****bitter = painful / deeply disappointing (痛苦的；令人難受的) — 苦澀；痛苦****

A major figurative extension.

Practice 12

> “It was a ****bitter disappointment****.”

「那是一次****令人極度失望 / 苦澀的失望****。」

Practice 13

> “Defeat was a bitter experience for the team.”

「失敗對球隊來說是一段****痛苦的經歷****。」

****bitter = 某種經歷 / 結果令人深感痛苦、失望或難以接受****

7. ****bitter disappointment (極度失望) — 沉痛失望 ; 苦澀失望****

Practice 14

> “Losing the final was a ****bitter disappointment****.”

「輸掉決賽是一次****沉痛的失望****。」

Practice 15

> “It was a bitter disappointment after months of work.”

「努力數月後得到這個結果，實在令人****非常失望和苦澀****。」

****bitter disappointment = 強烈而痛苦、令人難以接受的失望****

8. ****bitter experience/memory (痛苦經歷 / 回憶) — 苦澀 ; 痛苦****

Practice 16

> “The argument left ****bitter memories****.”

「那次爭執留下了****痛苦 / 苦澀的回憶****。」

Practice 17

> “It was a bitter experience, but she learned from it.”

「那是一段****痛苦的經歷****，但她從中學到了東西。」

****bitter experience/memory = 令人痛苦、不愉快並留下負面情緒的經歷 / 回憶****

9. ****bitter = involving intense hostility (激烈敵對的) — 激烈的 ; 充滿敵意的****

A major separate figurative sense.

Practice 18

> “They had a ****bitter argument****.”

「他們發生了一場****激烈的爭吵****。」

Practice 19

> “The issue caused a bitter dispute.”

「這個問題引起了****激烈而充滿敵意的爭議****。」

****bitter = 衝突、爭論或競爭中帶有強烈憤怒、敵意或怨恨****

10. ****bitter argument/dispute (激烈爭吵 / 爭議) — 激烈；充滿敵意****

Practice 20

> “A ****bitter dispute**** developed between the two groups.”

「兩個群體之間爆發了****激烈的爭議****。」

Practice 21

> “Their disagreement turned into a bitter argument.”

「他們的分歧演變成一場****激烈爭吵****。」

****bitter argument/dispute = 情緒強烈、充滿敵意和不滿的爭論****

11. ****bitter rivals (死對頭 / 激烈競爭者) — 競爭激烈、彼此敵對的對手****

Practice 22

> “The two teams are ****bitter rivals****.”

「這兩支球隊是****死對頭 / 宿敵****。」

Practice 23

> “The companies have been bitter rivals for years.”

「兩家公司多年來一直是****競爭激烈的對手****。」

****bitter rivals = 長期競爭激烈、關係充滿敵意的對手****

12. ****bitter enemy (死敵) — 宿敵 ; 仇敵****

Practice 24

> “They became ****bitter enemies****.”

「他們變成了****死敵****。」

Practice 25

> “Former friends can sometimes become bitter enemies.”

「昔日朋友有時會變成****仇敵****。」

****bitter enemy = 彼此有強烈仇恨 / 敵意的敵人****

13. ****bitter = extremely cold (嚴寒的) — 刺骨寒冷 ; 嚴寒****

A major weather sense.

Practice 26

> “It was a ****bitter winter morning****.”

「那是一個****寒冷刺骨的冬日早晨****。」

Practice 27

> “We went outside in the bitter cold.”

「我們冒著****刺骨嚴寒****走到外面。」

****bitter = 寒冷程度非常強烈，令人感到刺骨 / 難受****

14. **bitter cold (嚴寒) — 刺骨寒冷**

Practice 28

> “They waited outside in the **bitter cold**.”

「他們在**刺骨的寒冷中**在外等候。」

Practice 29

> “The bitter cold made walking difficult.”

「**嚴寒**令步行變得困難。」

bitter cold = 極度寒冷、令人身體不適的天氣 / 氣溫

15. **bitter wind (寒風刺骨) — 刺骨寒風**

Practice 30

> “A **bitter wind** blew across the field.”

「一陣**刺骨寒風**吹過田野。」

Practice 31

> “The bitter wind made my eyes water.”

「**寒風刺骨**，令我雙眼流淚。」

bitter wind = 非常寒冷、令人感到刺痛的風

16. **bitter = harsh / difficult to accept (殘酷而難接受的) — 苦澀；難以接受**

A figurative extension common in expressions such as **bitter truth**.

Practice 32

> “He finally accepted the **bitter truth**.”

「他終於接受了那個**殘酷而難以接受的事實**。」

Practice 33

> “The result was a bitter reminder of their earlier failure.”

「這個結果令人**痛苦地再次想起**他們之前的失敗。」

****bitter = 事實 / 現實令人痛苦、失望，但不得不接受****

17. ****bitter truth (殘酷事實) — 苦澀真相；殘酷事實****

Practice 34

> “The ****bitter truth**** was that they had run out of time.”

「****殘酷的事實****是他們已經沒有時間了。」

Practice 35

> “Sometimes people avoid facing a bitter truth.”

「人有時會避免面對****難以接受的事實****。」

****bitter truth = 真實但令人痛苦 / 失望而難以接受的事實****

18. ****bitter end (堅持到最後 / 痛苦結局；固定表達) — 到最後；直到結束****

The phrase ****to the bitter end**** is a major idiom.

Practice 36

> “She supported the team ****to the bitter end****.”

「她一直支持球隊****直到最後一刻****。」

Practice 37

> “They were determined to continue to the bitter end.”

「他們決心****堅持到底****。」

****to the bitter end = 一直堅持到事情完全結束，即使過程困難 / 結果不理想****

The phrase is lexicalized; learners should not interpret ****bitter**** here simply as taste.

19. ****bitterly** = with strong resentment or anger (怨恨地 / 憤怒地) — 憤憤不平地******

A major related adverb.

Practice 38

> “He complained ****bitterly**** about the decision.”

「他對這個決定****極度不滿地抱怨****。」

Practice 39

> “She spoke bitterly about how she had been treated.”

「她談到自己受到的待遇時語氣充滿****怨恨****。」

****bitterly** = 帶著強烈怨氣、憤怒或不滿地******

20. ****complain bitterly** (強烈抱怨) — 怨聲載道；強烈不滿地抱怨******

Practice 40

> “Customers ****complained bitterly**** about the delays.”

「顧客對延誤****強烈抱怨****。」

Practice 41

> “He complained bitterly that nobody had listened.”

「他****非常不滿地抱怨****沒有人聽他的話。」

****complain bitterly** = 帶著強烈不滿、憤怒或怨氣抱怨******

21. ****bitterly** = extremely / deeply with negative emotion (極度地) — 非常；深深地******

A major intensifying use.

Practice 42

> “She was ****bitterly disappointed****.”

「她感到****極度失望****。」

Practice 43

> “He bitterly regretted the decision.”

「他對那個決定感到****非常後悔****。」

****bitterly + negative emotion = 強調失望、後悔等負面情緒程度非常強****

22. ****bitterly disappointed (極度失望) — 非常失望****

Practice 44

> “They were ****bitterly disappointed**** by the result.”

「他們對結果感到****極度失望****。」

Practice 45

> “She was bitterly disappointed not to be selected.”

「她因未獲選而感到****非常失望****。」

****bitterly disappointed = 失望程度非常深，而且常伴隨痛苦 / 不滿****

23. ****bitterness = bitter taste (苦味) — 苦味；苦澀****

The related noun retains the literal taste meaning.

Practice 46

> “The sugar reduced the ****bitterness**** of the coffee.”

「糖減低了咖啡的****苦味****。」

Practice 47

> “The drink has a slight bitterness.”

「這款飲品帶有淡淡的**苦味**。」

****bitterness = 食物 / 飲品中苦味的性質或程度****

24. ****bitterness = resentment (怨恨) — 怨恨；憤懣****

A major figurative noun sense.

Practice 48

> “She spoke without ****bitterness****.”

「她說話時沒有帶著****怨恨****。」

Practice 49

> “Years of conflict created deep bitterness.”

「多年的衝突造成了深深的****怨恨****。」

****bitterness = 因傷害、不公平或失望而長期存在的怨恨 / 憤懣情緒****

This directly corresponds to the passage meaning.

25. ****bitterness between people/groups (彼此怨恨) — 敵意；積怨****

Practice 50

> “There was considerable ****bitterness between the two families****.”

「兩個家庭之間有很深的****積怨****。」

Practice 51

> “The dispute left lasting bitterness.”

「爭議留下了長久的****怨恨和敵意****。」

****bitterness between X and Y = 雙方因過去衝突而留下的強烈不滿 / 敵意****

26. **bitters** (苦味酒 / 苦精) — 苦精 ; 苦味調味酒

A useful lexical family member, especially in food/drink contexts.

Practice 52

> “The recipe uses a few drops of **bitters**.”

「這個配方用了幾滴**苦精**。」

Practice 53

> “Bitters are often used in mixed drinks.”

「**苦精**常用於調製飲品。」

bitters = 由草本、香料等製成、味道濃烈而苦的調味液體

This is a lexicalized plural noun and should not be confused with ordinary adjective **bitter**.

Important distinction: **bitter** vs **sour**

This is one of the most important literal taste contrasts.

bitter

= 苦

Typical examples:

- * black coffee;
- * some medicines;
- * dark leafy vegetables.

sour

= 酸

Typical examples:

- * lemon;
- * vinegar;

* unripe fruit.

So:

> bitter ≠ sour.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs sweet****

These are often treated as contrasting taste qualities.

****bitter****

= 苦的

****sweet****

= 甜的

But a food can contain both:

> bittersweet chocolate.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs spicy****

****bitter****

= a taste quality.

****spicy****

= containing strong spices / producing heat or pungency.

Coffee may be bitter without being spicy.

Chilli may be spicy without being bitter.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs resentful****

In the passage sense, these are close.

resentful

= feeling anger because you think you were treated unfairly.

bitter

= often stronger and more enduring; the resentment has affected your overall attitude.

So:

> **bitter**

can suggest a person has become emotionally hardened by their experience.

That is why it works so well in your passage.

Important distinction: **bitter vs angry**

angry

= currently feeling anger.

bitter

= carrying longer-term resentment because of past hurt, disappointment, or unfairness.

Someone can be angry for ten minutes.

Being bitter usually suggests something more lasting.

Important distinction: **bitter vs upset**

upset

= unhappy, worried, or emotionally disturbed.

bitter

= specifically carries resentment and often a sense of unfairness.

So **bitter** is much more specific.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs disappointed****

****disappointed****

= unhappy because hopes/expectations were not met.

****bitter****

= resentment may develop because of repeated or serious disappointment.

A person can be disappointed without becoming bitter.

This distinction is central to your sentence.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs cynical****

These can overlap but are not identical.

****bitter****

= resentful because of painful experiences.

****cynical****

= distrustful of people's motives, often assuming selfishness or insincerity.

Hardship can make a person:

> bitter,

> cynical,

or both.

But they are different attitudes.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs pessimistic****

****bitter****

= resentful about past treatment/experience.

****pessimistic****

= expects bad outcomes in the future.

A bitter person is not necessarily pessimistic, and vice versa.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs hostile****

****hostile****

= openly unfriendly/aggressive.

****bitter****

= internally resentful; hostility may or may not be expressed openly.

So ****bitter**** focuses more on emotional state.

Important distinction: ****bitter experience vs difficult experience****

****difficult experience****

= hard to deal with.

****bitter experience****

= painful and emotionally unpleasant, often leaving disappointment or resentment.

****Bitter**** adds emotional pain.

Important distinction: ****bitter disappointment vs deep disappointment****

Both are strong.

****deep disappointment****

= very strong disappointment.

bitter disappointment

= strong disappointment with an added sense of painful frustration or unfairness.

Important distinction: **bitter argument vs serious argument**

serious argument

could mean:

> important/intense disagreement.

bitter argument

specifically suggests:

> anger + hostility + resentment.

So **bitter** describes emotional tone.

Important distinction: **bitter rivals vs strong rivals**

strong rivals

= competitors of similar high ability.

bitter rivals

= competitors with strong hostility/animosity toward each other.

Very different.

Important distinction: **bitter enemy vs opponent**

opponent

= someone on the other side of a contest/disagreement.

bitter enemy

= someone toward whom there is strong personal or long-term hostility.

An opponent is not necessarily an enemy.

Important distinction: ****bitter cold vs very cold****

Both indicate low temperature.

****very cold****

= neutral description.

****bitter cold****

= emphasizes that the cold feels harsh, painful, and penetrating.

So:

> bitter cold

≈ 刺骨嚴寒.

Important distinction: ****bitter truth vs unpleasant truth****

They overlap.

****unpleasant truth****

= not nice to hear.

****bitter truth****

= particularly painful, disappointing, or emotionally hard to accept.

****Bitter**** is more expressive.

Important distinction: ****bitterly disappointed vs bitter person****

These contain related emotional imagery, but their grammar differs.

****bitterly disappointed****

= extremely/deeply disappointed.

It does not necessarily mean the person has become resentful long-term.

****a bitter person****

= a person characterized by lasting resentment.

Important not to over-interpret the adverb.

Important distinction: ****bitterly vs badly****

****bitterly disappointed****

= extremely disappointed, with emotional pain.

****badly disappointed****

exists in some varieties/contexts but is much less idiomatic as the standard collocation.

****Bitterly disappointed**** is a useful fixed combination.

Important distinction: ****bitter vs bittersweet****

****bitter****

= painful, resentful, or literally bitter.

****bittersweet****

= containing both happiness/pleasure and sadness.

> “Leaving school was bittersweet.”

= 離開學校令人既開心又傷感。

****Bittersweet**** deserves recognition as a useful related compound, but it is not merely “very bitter.”

27. ****bittersweet** (苦樂參半的) — 既甜蜜又傷感 ; 苦樂參半******

A useful family extension.

Practice 54

> “Saying goodbye was ****bittersweet****.”

「道別的感覺****苦樂參半****。」

Practice 55

> “It was a bittersweet memory.”

「那是一段****既美好又令人傷感的回憶****。」

****bittersweet** = 同時包含愉快 / 美好與傷感 / 痛苦的感受******

Family-extension sweep

The practical ****bitter**** family is rich but semantically coherent: a harsh taste develops metaphorically into harsh emotional experiences, hostility, and severe physical sensation.

- * ****bitter — taste**** = 苦的
- * ****bitter taste/flavour**** = 苦味 / 苦澀味
- * ****bitter — resentful**** = 怨恨的 / 憤憤不平的
- * ****become bitter**** = 因不愉快經歷而變得怨恨
- * ****bitter about something**** = 對某事耿耿於懷
- * ****bitter toward someone**** = 對某人心懷怨恨
- * ****bitter disappointment**** = 沉痛 / 強烈失望
- * ****bitter experience/memory**** = 痛苦 / 苦澀經歷或回憶
- * ****bitter argument/dispute**** = 激烈、充滿敵意的爭論
- * ****bitter rivals**** = 宿敵 / 死對頭
- * ****bitter enemy**** = 死敵 / 仇敵
- * ****bitter cold**** = 刺骨嚴寒
- * ****bitter wind**** = 刺骨寒風
- * ****bitter truth**** = 殘酷而難以接受的事實
- * ****to the bitter end**** = 堅持到底 / 直到最後
- * ****bitterly — resentfully**** = 怨恨 / 強烈不滿地
- * ****complain bitterly**** = 強烈不滿地抱怨
- * ****bitterly disappointed**** = 極度失望
- * ****bitterness — taste**** = 苦味
- * ****bitterness — resentment**** = 怨恨 / 積怨
- * ****bitters**** = 苦精

* **bittersweet** = 苦樂參半的

The main semantic branches are:

> **sharp unpleasant taste**

> **lasting resentment caused by suffering/unfairness**

> **painful or deeply disappointing experience**

> **intense hostility or conflict**

> **extreme cold**

All of these metaphorically preserve the idea of something:

> **harsh, unpleasant, and difficult to endure.**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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bitter — taste	食物 / 飲品帶有強烈、通常不令人愉快的苦味
bitter — resentful	因痛苦、不公平或失望而長期帶著怨恨和憤怒
bitter about X	因某件不愉快 / 不公平的事情長時間耿耿於懷
bitter toward someone	因過去傷害 / 不公平待遇而對某人持續懷恨
bitter disappointment	強烈、痛苦而令人難以接受的失望
bitter experience/memory	帶來強烈痛苦、失望或負面情緒的經歷 / 回憶
bitter argument/dispute	情緒激烈並充滿敵意、怨恨的爭論
bitter rivals	長期競爭激烈並彼此有強烈敵意的對手
bitter enemy	彼此存在強烈、持續仇恨的敵人
bitter cold	寒冷程度極強、令人感到刺痛難受
bitter truth	真實但令人痛苦、失望而難以接受的事實
to the bitter end	即使困難 / 不愉快仍一直堅持到完全結束
bitterly — resentfully	帶著強烈怨氣、憤怒或不滿地
bitterly disappointed	感到極度、痛苦地失望
bitterness — taste	食物 / 飲品中苦味的性質或程度
bitterness — resentment	因傷害、不公平或失望而長期存在的怨恨 / 憤懣
bitters	用於飲品等、具有濃烈苦味的草本調味液
bittersweet	同時帶有快樂 / 美好及悲傷 / 痛苦的感受；苦樂參半

For your original passage

> “I also admire the way she has handled hardship in life without becoming ****bitter****.”

The exact meaning is:

****bitter = resentful, angry, or emotionally hardened because of painful experiences****

Therefore:

> ****without becoming bitter****

= ****「沒有因為人生的困難而變得怨恨、憤憤不平或對世界充滿不滿」****

This is a particularly meaningful word choice in the passage.

Your grandmother has experienced:

> ****hardship****

but hardship has not changed her into someone who:

- * resents other people;
- * constantly complains about unfairness;
- * becomes cold or hostile;
- * loses her kindness.

That creates the contrast:

> ****hardship****

> → could produce bitterness

but in her case:

> ****hardship****

> → did not destroy kindness.

This is why ****bitter**** is stronger than simply:

> sad

or:

> disappointed.

A person can be:

> sad about hardship

without being:

> bitter.

****Bitter**** implies that the pain has turned into ****lasting resentment****.

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****bitter coffee****

> = 苦咖啡

> ****become bitter after hardship****

> = 因困境而變得怨恨

> ****be bitter about the past****

> = 對過去耿耿於懷

> ****a bitter disappointment****

> = 沉痛 / 極度的失望

> ****a bitter argument****

> = 激烈而充滿敵意的爭吵

> ****bitter rivals****

> = 死對頭 / 宿敵

> ****a bitter enemy****

> = 死敵

> ****bitter cold****

> = 刺骨嚴寒

> ****the bitter truth****

> = 殘酷而難以接受的真相

> ****to the bitter end****

> = 堅持到底

> ****complain bitterly****

> = 強烈不滿地抱怨

> ****bitterly disappointed****

> = 極度失望

> ****bitterness****

> = 苦味 ; 怨恨

> ****bittersweet****

> = 苦樂參半

So ****bitter**** is much richer than simply:

> ****bitter = 苦的****

and in your original passage it specifically means:

****“to become full of lasting resentment or anger because of the hardships and disappointments one has experienced.”****